

IELTS

BAND 7

CHEATSHEET

25 Rules That Separate
Band 6 from Band 7

WRITING

READING

LISTENING

SPEAKING

Free download at:

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Reviewed against official IELTS Band Descriptors
— British Council & IDP





WRITING TASK 1 — 3 Key Rules for Band 7



SCORE CRITERIA

Task Achievement · Coherence & Cohesion · Lexical Resource · Grammatical Range

20 minutes · 150+ words · Describe a graph, chart, map or process

Rule 1: Describe the Trend, Not Just the Number

■ Band 5–6 (Avoid)	■ Band 7 (Correct)
"In 1990 the figure was 30%. In 2000 it was 45%."	"The proportion increased significantly from 30% in 1990 to 45% in 2000 — a 15 percentage point rise over the decade."

Use trend language: rose sharply · declined gradually · remained stable · peaked at · fell to a low of

Rule 2: Use the Overview Paragraph — It Is Non-Negotiable

Write 2 sentences immediately after the introduction. State the 2–3 most significant features **without specific numbers**. No Overview = maximum Band 6, even with perfect grammar.

OVERVIEW TEMPLATE

Overall, it is clear that [main trend 1], while [main trend 2]. [Category X] consistently showed the highest/lowest [figure].

Rule 3: Group Data — Do Not Describe Line by Line

If a chart has 6 countries, **do NOT** describe each one separately. Group by performance — this is what Coherence & Cohesion looks like at Band 7:

- Countries with the **highest** figures: ...
- Countries with **moderate** figures: ...
- Countries with the **lowest** figures: ...



WRITING TASK 2 — Band 7 Structure Template



TASK INFO

40 minutes · 250+ words · Four types: Opinion, Discussion, Problem/Solution, Advantages/Disadvantages

The Band 7 Five-Paragraph Structure

Para	Section	Content
1	INTRODUCTION	Paraphrase the question + state your position
2	BODY 1	Topic sentence → Explain → Example → Effect
3	BODY 2	Topic sentence → Explain → Example → Effect
4	CONCESSION (if needed)	"While some argue that... this view overlooks..."
5	CONCLUSION	Restate position + summarize + forward-look

INTRODUCTION TEMPLATE

[Paraphrased topic] has become a subject of increasing debate in recent years. While some argue that [opposing view], I firmly believe that [your position] because [brief reason].

BODY PARAGRAPH TEMPLATE

[Topic sentence]. This is because [explanation]. For instance, [specific real-world example]. As a result, [consequence]. Therefore, [link back to the main argument].

3 Band 7 Grammar Rules

- 1. Use complex sentences.** Every paragraph must have at least one relative clause (who/which/that), conditional (if/unless), or concession (although/despite/while).
- 2. Never repeat the same word twice in one paragraph.** Use synonyms: 'children' → 'young people', 'minors', 'the younger generation'
- 3. Avoid 'In my opinion I think that...'** It is redundant. Use ONE marker only: 'I believe...' OR 'In my view...'

■ READING — 3 Speed Techniques



SCORE TARGET

3 passages · 40 questions · 60 minutes · Band 7 requires ~30–32 correct out of 40

Technique 1: Keywords First, Passage Second

Never read the passage first. Go to the questions, underline key content words (nouns, names, numbers, dates — NOT articles/prepositions), then scan for those words.

SPEED GAIN

Cuts average reading time per question from 3 minutes down to 90 seconds.

Technique 2: True / False / Not Given — The One Rule That Fixes It

Answer	The Rule
TRUE	The passage DIRECTLY confirms the statement (same meaning)
FALSE	The passage DIRECTLY contradicts the statement (opposite meaning)
NOT GIVEN	The passage does not say it either way — no information at all

WATCH OUT

Common mistake: Students choose TRUE when the information 'probably makes sense.' If it is not explicitly stated in the text → it is NOT GIVEN.

Technique 3: Matching Headings — Eliminate, Don't Select

Do NOT try to find the 'best' heading. Use elimination instead:

- **Step 1:** Read only the opening and closing sentence of the paragraph
- **Step 2:** Eliminate headings that are clearly wrong
- **Step 3:** Choose from the remaining 2–3 options

■ LISTENING — 3 Prediction Tricks



SCORE TARGET

4 sections · 40 questions · ~30 minutes of audio · Band 7 requires ~30 correct

Trick 1: Use the 30-Second Gap to Predict

Before each section begins, use the 30 seconds to read ahead:

- Identify **what type of information is missing** (a name? number? date? reason?)
- Predict the **word class** you need (noun? adjective? verb?)
- **Circle proper nouns** so you listen for them specifically

Trick 2: Listen for Signpost Words

Signpost Word	Meaning
"The reason is..."	Your answer follows immediately
"The main problem is..."	Your answer follows immediately
"However..." / "But actually..."	Previous info was wrong — this IS the correction
"So that means..."	Implication = likely your answer

Trick 3: Expect Distractors — The Final Answer Wins

In IELTS Listening, speakers often self-correct. **The final stated answer is always correct.**

■ Band 5–6 (Avoid)	■ Band 7 (Correct)
"We'll meet on Tuesday..." → Student writes: Tuesday	"We'll meet on Tuesday — actually, let's make it Wednesday." → Correct answer: Wednesday

DISTRACTOR WARNING

Also watch for number corrections: 'The price is \$45... wait, with the discount it's \$38.' Always wait for the speaker to finish their complete thought before writing.

■■ SPEAKING — 10 Band 7 Vocabulary Phrases



TEST INFO

3 parts · 11–14 minutes · Assessed on: Fluency, Lexical Resource, Grammar, Pronunciation

Band 5–6 vocabulary is basic and repetitive. **Band 7 vocabulary** is precise, idiomatic, and natural. Replace these 10 phrases:

■ Avoid (Band 5–6)	■ Use Instead (Band 7)	Example
It is very important	It plays a crucial role in...	Technology plays a crucial role in modern education.
Many people think	There is a growing consensus that...	There is a growing consensus that remote work boosts productivity.
A lot of	A significant proportion of...	A significant proportion of young people prefer streaming to TV.
Good for environment	Environmentally sustainable	Electric vehicles are far more environmentally sustainable.
I think (repeated)	From my perspective... / In my experience...	From my perspective, family support is irreplaceable.
Bad effect	detrimental impact on...	Pollution has a detrimental impact on public health.
Because of this	As a consequence... / This has led to...	As a consequence, many families have relocated.
Very fast	at an unprecedented rate	Technology is advancing at an unprecedented rate.
Help people	empower individuals to...	Online learning empowers individuals to study at their own pace.
I don't know (stuck)	That's an interesting question. Let me think...	Buy 3–5 seconds — examiners reward it as natural strategy.

FLUENCY TIP

Use "That's an interesting question. Let me think about that for a moment..." any time you need 3–5 seconds. Examiners are trained to reward this — not penalize it.

COMMON MISTAKES That Block Band 7



These patterns keep students stuck at Band 5–6. Identify which ones apply to you.

Writing Mistakes

- ✗ Copying question words without paraphrasing in the introduction
- ✗ Writing the Overview at the END instead of paragraph 2
- ✗ Using vague examples ('in many countries') — be specific
- ✗ Only using 'firstly / secondly / finally' for cohesion
- ✗ Writing under 250 words in Task 2 — automatic score penalty

Speaking Mistakes

- ✗ One-sentence answers — always extend with 'because / for example / which means that'
- ✗ Memorized rehearsed answers — examiners are trained to detect and penalize these
- ✗ Over-correcting mid-sentence — say the next best word, not the perfect word
- ✗ Ignoring Part 2 timing — practice speaking for exactly 1 min 45 sec

Reading Mistakes

- ✗ Reading the whole passage before looking at the questions
- ✗ Spending more than 90 seconds per question — move on and return
- ✗ Changing a correct answer to an incorrect one (first instinct is usually right)

Listening Mistakes

- ✗ Spelling errors — British spelling: colour, organisation, programme
- ✗ Missing plural/singular — 'books' and 'book' are marked as different answers
- ✗ Not checking transfer answers carefully in the final transfer period

Ready to go from Band 6 to Band 7?

This cheatsheet gives you the rules.
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